

Grande Prairie issues data centre development permit near Sexsmith | Edmonton Journal

Category: Honeybee and Pollinator Vibroacoustics & EMF | Evidence ID: #059

Archived: 2026-10-04 20:15

- **Original URL:** <https://edmontonjournal.com/news/county-of-grande-prairie-issues-ai-data-centre-development-permit-near-sexsmith>
 - **Research Category:** Honeybee and Pollinator Vibroacoustics & EMF
 - **Archival File:** 059_edmontonjournal_com_news_county-of-grande-prairie-issue.pdf
 - **Extraction Status:** Full Web Transcript PDF
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Source Content

County of Grande Prairie issues data centre development permit near Sexsmith A recent development permit from the County of Grande Prairie has prompted officials to change how similar projects will be reviewed after residents raised concerns about transparency and public input The County of Grande Prairie has issued a development permit for an AI data centre near Sexsmith, prompting officials to change how similar projects will be reviewed after residents raised concerns about the approval process. The permit, issued for a proposed development in the Emerson Trail area, allows for five buildings measuring 80 by 180 feet and 15 accessory structures measuring eight by 20 feet for make-up air (MUA) generators. The application met the existing land-use requirements and was approved through the administrative process, residents questioned why they had not been given more information about the project and its potential impacts. Some of the reaction played out on social media. "If you value your water and bees and noise free time you had better stop it in its tracks asap. They are bad news," wrote Raymond N Shura in a social media comment. Other residents contacted county officials directly, prompting the county to publicly acknowledge the concerns. "There are questions and concerns in the community regarding the recently approved development permit for a proposed data centre," read the county's public response. "The County recognizes the significant public interest in this project and understands that residents want more information about the approval and what it means." The county has since changed its process for future data centre applications. The development permit initially fell under the county's Land Use Bylaw (LUB), which was approved in 2003 and has been adjusted over the years to accommodate changing practices and developments. County reeve Amanda McDonald said data centres have been included as a recognized use under the LUB for several years, but the facilities being proposed today are different in scale from those originally contemplated. When the application was reviewed, it met the existing land-use requirements, she said. The county now recognizes the concerns residents have about how projects of this type are reviewed and is addressing them through the approval process, McDonald said. "Since this conversation, we have asked for all of those, anything that fits under the right zoning, but is a development permit that fits under a data centre, that it would come to the municipal planning commission." The county has not released the name of the developer. However, the landowners' names appear on land-use change applications considered at an Aug. 10 hearing. Before the development permit was issued, the owners applied to change the land-use designations to accommodate development on the properties. One area was changed from agricultural use to a designation that allows development near major highways or roadways and

has greater visibility. The other was changed from agricultural use to a designation that allows higher-impact utility, industrial or manufacturing sites. The listed owners on both applications were Christopher Balderston, Pamela Balderston and Ryan Curry. One of the applications also listed RB Curry Auto Transport as a business name. The locations listed on the land-use applications are consistent with the area identified in the development permit. Christopher Balderston's public LinkedIn profile lists him as CEO of Ground Level Land Corp., which describes itself as "a privately owned real estate investment group concentrating on the acquisition, planning and development of strategically located land in the rapidly expanding County of Grande Prairie, Alberta." The AI data centre address is also listed as a future development in Ground Level's Redtail Business Park, one of the company's projects. The county has not confirmed whether the individuals or companies named on the land-use applications are associated with the development permit. Provincial approvals still required The county's issuance of a development permit does not mean the project can immediately proceed. The development must still meet requirements set by the province and its various agencies, McDonald said. The project is also consistent with the province's AI data centre strategy, she said. Provincial decisions can limit what the municipality is able to require of a development, McDonald said. If the province were to waive an environmental impact assessment, for example, the county's ability to impose additional requirements would be limited. At that point, the municipality's primary option would be to advocate to the relevant provincial ministries, she said. "When something comes approved with an Alberta Energy license, and we're looking at a development permit, we're very limited in what we can add to the restrictions. We can make them put up a fence or make them direct light a certain way, for instance." Bookmark our website and support our journalism: Don't miss the news you need to know — add EdmontonJournal.com and EdmontonSun.com to your bookmarks and sign up for our newsletters here. You can also support our journalism by becoming a digital subscriber. Subscribers gain unlimited access to The Edmonton Journal, Edmonton Sun, National Post and 13 other Canadian news sites. Support us by subscribing today: [The Edmonton Journal](http://TheEdmontonJournal.com) | [The Edmonton Sun](http://TheEdmontonSun.com). Postmedia is committed to maintaining a lively but civil forum for discussion. Please keep comments relevant and respectful. Comments may take up to an hour to appear on the site. You will receive an email if there is a reply to your comment, an update to a thread you follow or if a user you follow comments. Visit our [Community Guidelines](#) for more information.